

But, with all the in-house innovation done by Just Dial's IT team, did the development costs dilute the overall cost advantage somewhere down the lane? Just Dial believes that when working on something fundamentally core to its business proposition, sometimes what is viewed as an outgoing cost could be what builds immense value for the firm. So Just Dial chose to invest heavily in customising open source, confident that it would turn into a good investment. "We wanted to be different and were ready to absorb some costs, which also included time. We believed in getting it right the first time and in constant improvement. Our revenue growth speaks of our success in changing this cost centre into an investment. Despite the money we have put in to changing pathways, we have grown our revenues by two times after moving to open source," says Chattopadhyay.

Improved customer satisfaction and flexibility

The open source architecture provided greater flexibility, which in turn led to indirect improvements in customer satisfaction. "Open source has given us great flexibility. For instance, if I got a great algorithm for a map search, I am confident that it could be made to work on the Red Hat platform. Such flexibility allowed us to experiment, develop and opt for tools and algorithms to optimise our data structures. The proficiency we achieved led to an indirect increase in efficiency and customer satisfaction. Besides this, discussions with the community opened up new horizons helping us come up with better products for our customers," says Chattopadhyay.

Perfect alignment with growth vision

Open source fuelled Just Dial's meteoric growth. "We were in just seven cities in 2007. Only when we switched to open source did we see the chance to grow to 240 cities on a single national number—69999999. Open source technology aligned with and fostered our vision of growth. It made us realise we could grow at a much faster rate," says Chattopadhyay. Looking ahead, open source will continue to be the force powering Just Dial's ambitious plans to expand outside India. "We have already launched our services in the US, and in the near future we will expand to most of the English speaking countries. The way we are as a company – impulsive and focused on the market – only open source can keep up with us," says Chattopadhyay.

Easy maintenance

Maintenance of such an infrastructure could have been a nightmare, especially with all the innovation embedded into it. Red Hat support, along with Just Dial's fully equipped IT team, helped the company address this challenge without too much trouble. "Red Hat support, along with our IT team of about 40 people on the infrastructure side (managing Linux and the servers) and another 90 people on the development side (working on database management, core C programming, the user interface, and backend page scripting) helped us maintain our infrastructure with great ease," says Chattopadhyay.

The relationship just seems to get stronger

Looking ahead, open source technology will continue to be Just Dial's first love. The firm has plans to opt for an open source application server soon. "Since we have consolidated and arrived at a convergence of the modules and IT requirements, we are looking for an open source application server with tidy coding and a plan to build around it. We have benchmarked one, called Yii, that works with any C component, making it a perfect fit for us. Yii's memory management for connection pooling of databases promises to give us a big advantage. It also has a lot of fault tolerance and sharing. Lastly, Yii has good community backing; it has grown in the right fashion with a loyal fan base," says Chattopadhyay.

With Fedora coming under the Red Hat umbrella and having rectified its network stack issues, Just Dial plans to experiment with Fedora 13. "Also, with the fate of MySQL shaky, the company is looking at other DBMS options like Flash DB, XtraDB, MariaDB, etc.," says Chattopadhyay. With such achievements to their joint credit, Just Dial will remain an ardent open source fan and user.  **END**

By: **Vanisha Joseph**

The author loves to experiment, and writing for *LINUX For You* is her latest experiment—so beware! Just a minute, she also happens to be a journalist during the day.

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